

Orval N.P. Theisen was a long-time physics and science teacher at North Central High School in Spokane, Washington. Born in South Dakota in 1916, he passed away in Spokane in August 2007 at the age of 91.

His biographical and historical background details include:

- Background & Education:** Orval N.P. Theisen was born in Erwin, Kingsbury, South Dakota on January 14, 1916.
- Early Career & Military:** Before his teaching career, he served in the U.S. military, including the Army Air Corps and later the Air Force, from January 1943 to October 1945. He served as a radio operator and gunner on B-17s, participating in 35 bombing missions over central Europe.
- Personal Life:** He married Anna Aileene Cantlon in Spokane on January 5, 1946.
- Teaching Career:** He spent decades as a physics and science instructor at North Central High School, where he taught alongside science department head Ernest Hix. He was an active educator, even publishing in *The Physics Teacher* journal in the early 1970s.
- Death:** He died on August 7, 2007, and was laid to rest in the Spokane area.

You can review his brief family and historical timeline via the [FamilySearch Life History for Orval Theisen](#).

Norman W. Erickson was a business and mathematics teacher at North Central High School in Spokane from 1956 until his retirement in 1979. He passed away in July 1999. He is survived by his wife, Marjorie (Henniger) Erickson, four children, and five grandchildren.

Additional biographical and obituary details include:

- Early Life & Education:** He was a Spokane native who initially worked for Madison Lumber in 1948 and Watson Management in 1950. He later attended Washington State University and Eastern Washington University, where he earned his teaching degree in 1956.
- Professional Associations:** During his career, he was a member of the Retired Teachers, Spokane Education, and Washington Education associations, as well as the Moose Lodge.
- Obituary:** The full death notice was published on July 13, 1999, and is accessible in the [Spokesman-Review Archives](#).

John P. Rodkey served as the beloved principal of North Central High School in Spokane, Washington, from 1959 until 1979. Born in 1921, he passed away on May 16, 2012. Before his long career in education, he served as a radio operator in the Army Air Forces during WWII.

Life and Legacy:

- Background:** Born on a farm in Colorado, his family relocated to Post Falls, Idaho, during the Great Depression.
 - Career:** He spent 20 years at the helm of North Central High School, bringing deep compassion, grace, and energy to the student body.
 - Personal Life:** He was married, raised three children, and was a dedicated member of his church who valued faith, learning, and storytelling.
- You can read more about his remarkable life or pay tribute through the full [Obituary for John P. Rodkey](#) published by Heritage Funeral & Cremation, or explore his legacy feature in the [Spokesman-Review](#).

<https://www.legacy.com/us/obituaries/spokesman/name/john-rodkey-obituary?id=15851919>

<https://www.legacy.com/funeral-homes/obituaries/name/john-rodkey-obituary?pid=157749061&v=batesville&view=guestbook>

<https://www.spokesman.com/stories/2012/jan/26/education-of-a-lifetime>

<https://www.heritagefunerals.com/obituaries/john-p-rodkey-obid-3033903>

[https://dn790000.ca.archive.org/0/items/SPLYearbooksNorthCentral1963/SPL Yearbooks North Central 1963 text.pdf](https://dn790000.ca.archive.org/0/items/SPLYearbooksNorthCentral1963/SPL_Yearbooks_North_Central_1963_text.pdf)

Raymond Simonson taught science at North Central High School in Spokane, Washington, for over two decades, beginning his tenure at the school in the 1960s. Archival records confirm he taught classes like Biology and Chemistry before eventually shifting his focus fully to Chemistry.

Because local school district records and physical yearbooks from the 1976 era are primarily stored offline, extensive biographical details or an exact obituary are best sourced directly through local facilities. You can investigate specific dates and employment records using these localized research methods:

- Spokane Public Schools Archives:** You can look through physical archives, including older yearbooks (The "Totem"), which often feature faculty dedications and classroom photos. Learn more or contact the district administration via the [Spokane Public Schools](#) directory.
- Historical Newspaper Archives:** To track down Mr. Simonson's birth/death dates and obtain a formal obituary, you can search historic local publications. The *Spokesman-Review* serves the Spokane area and archives local historical obituaries.
- North Central Alumni Groups:** Connecting with groups like the "North Central High School Alumni & Friends" community on Facebook can help you reach former students who might have personal memories of his classroom and details on his retirement.

1963



Freedom Places Responsibility Upon the Individual

Some persons in this great land of ours, yes—and in this school of ours, are not very aware of the great responsibility that FREEDOM places upon the individual. If one considers what freedom really is, it becomes obvious that freedom means only that a person is free to do what he ought to do; He is also free to pay the penalty for wrong choices!

As we come to the end of another year it is good to think back on the past—and yet to look ahead to the future. First, may I thank you for the cooperation you have given the school this year. The courteous way you treat your friends, your teachers, and visitors to our building; your loyalty to your school; your participation in the activities of the school—these are the things that are REALLY important to you and to communities in which you will reside! We should never forget that the citizens of Spokane, through tax sources, provide educational opportunities for us that are unknown to most of the world. Where else does freedom abound? Where else does the individual have such free choice in determining his own future? "Where, oh where, but in America?"

Take time at the end of this year to say a word of appreciation—to parents, to friends, to teachers, to your community, to all who have given you assistance in developing yourself toward a worthwhile future.

To those who will not be returning to North Central next year we give our kindest regards and send our best wishes, especially to GRADUATES who will be finding their way into new experiences in life. May you retain fond memories of your years at North Central, and may that which you have learned assist you in attaining those positive goals you have established.

John P. Rodkey



1960

<https://dn721802.ca.archive.org/0/items/SPLYearbooksNorthCentral1960/SPL Yearbooks North Central 1960 text.pdf>



Principal John P. Rodkey

Now that it has ended . . .

The end of the year has come at last! With it have come the joys of anticipation for a summer of fun! Also has come the feeling of something worthwhile accomplished . . . or a feeling of something left undone.

To you who are leaving our family circle, we send our best wishes for many years of happiness as you assume the responsibilities of greater tasks, whether they be college, vocational training, employment, or family. It was pleasant to have known you these short years. Your absence will be keenly felt.

To you who remain, we anticipate your conscientious effort based upon a realization of the good things your community and your school desire for you.

Before we forget the accomplishments or frustrations of the past year, perhaps we should look again at the goals we have set for the future, goals which demand planning and preparation, that require our best effort, and goals that may change with new interests gained from experiences and learning. One of the basic facts of growth is this: **THERE IS NO PROGRESS WITHOUT EVALUATION.**

We express our deepest thanks for your co-operation and spirit during 1959-1960. You are proving that you are equal to the task of responsibility so vital to our country's need. May your summer be most enjoyable, and may it awaken in you new challenges for the future!

John P. Rodkey

P. H. Nygaard



Top row: P. H. Nygaard, department head; Robert Barnard, algebra; Dorothy Congdon, geometry; Burrill Exley, algebra; Edwin Kretz, algebra. Bottom row: William Lowther, algebra; William Nye, algebra; Mack Saunders, algebra.



Top row: Ernest Hix, department head; Dale E. Blair, biology; Raymond Simonson, biology; Walter Spangenburg, biology; Orval Thelsen, physics. Bottom row: Paul Tobie, geology; Madeline Carroll, head librarian; Lillian Barnes, assistant librarian.



SCIENCE

BUSINESS EDUCATION

Top row: James Griggs, department head; Norman Erickson, typing. Bottom row: Blair Glover, shorthand; A. A. Manfred, typing; Helen Stockdale, typing; Mary York, bookkeeping.



1960

William Nye, algebra
P. H. Nygaard, mathematics
department head
Mack L. Saunders, geometry
Robert F. Barnard, algebra



Dorothy Congdon, geometry
Burrill Exley, algebra
Raymond Simonson, biology
Paul Tobie, biology



https://ia800500.us.archive.org/19/items/SPLYearbooksNorthCentral1958/SPL_Yearbooks_North_Central_1958_text.pdf



https://ia800500.us.archive.org/19/items/SPLYearbooksNorthCentral1958/SPL_Yearbooks_North_Central_1958_text.pdf